The Nutcracker

Retold By E.T.A. Hoffman

INTRODUCTION

At Christmas time my mother always gets out the tree ornaments, something to hang on the door, a village, a nativity set, and The Nutcracker Retold by: E.T.A. Hoffman

It is Christmas Eve and glistening snow falls softly on a small town in Germany. Bright silver bells ring out through the frosty air as horse-drawn sleighs are pulled through the streets to the Silberhaus home. Judge Silberhaus, his wife, and their two children, Clara and Fritz, joyfully greet their guests as the scents of pine needles, cinnamon, and clove-studded apples draw the party to the ballroom. Gaily wrapped gifts are admired and then happily exchanged before the magnificent tree, laden with tiny glass ornaments, golden tinsel, and flickering candles.

Suddenly there appears a special guest, Clara's godfather, Doctor Drosselmeyer. It is rumored that he

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is not an ordinary doctor and that he possesses strange and mysterious powers. To Fritz, he gives a splendid army of small wooden soldiers. For Clara, there is a special surprise.

Doctor Drosselmeyer reaches deep within the folds of his satin cape and slowly withdraws a finely carved Nutcacker. "Oh, thank you, dear Godfather!" says Clara, gently cradling the doll while lightly stroking its soft curly beard. "Give him to me," Fritz demands, seeing what an excellent leader the Nutcracker will make for his new soldiers. He grabs the Nutcracker from Clara's arms, but as the starts across the room, he trips and drops the Nutcracker to the floor.
The Nutcracker is broken! Doctor Drosselmeyer picks up the doll and places it carefully in Clara's arms.

It is growing late and the party draws to a close. "Merry Christmas!" call the guests as they step out into the cold wintry night. Clara and Fritz are tucked into bed and kissed good night. The candles are snuffed, moonlight drifs through the frosted windows, and the house grows still….

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…except in Clara's room. Deep in the shadows, Doctor Drosselmeyer Quietly repairs the broken Nutcracker. When he has finished, he places the doll next to Clara and disappears.

The grandfather clock strikes 12 and awakens Clara. She hears a faint noise and sees her bedroom window slowly open.

Great gray mice pour into Clara's room, led by a ferocious mouse with seven heads—the Mouse King. Suddenly, the Nutcracker calls in Fritz's soldiers to lead them into battle.

Bayonets flash and hissing fills the air. Without warning, the Mouse King attacks the Nutcracker form behind. Clara screams and pulls the Mouse King's lashing tail. As the giant mouse turns toward Clara, the Nutcracker raises his sword and slays the giant mouse.

The Nutcracker turns and faces Clara. He is no longer a doll. He is now a young Prince. He removes a crown from the Mouse King and places it gently on Clara's head. "You saved my life," he says, "and I crown you Princess Clara. Come! My kingdom is near."

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The Prince takes Clara's hand and their journey begins. Sparkling snow falls about them though it is not cold.

They run through glittering ice crystals in the Land of Frost.

Soon they come to gates of sparkling spun sugar. Peppermint sticks line a candy road. The soft breezes of spring are all about them. "Hurry," says the Prince. "They are waiting."

At he end of the road stands a glowing castle, made entirely of marzipan. "Welcome," says the Sugar Plum Fairy. "Your kingdom awaits your return," trumpets sound and music fills the air, The celebration begins.

Clara and the Prince join hands and dance, and they dance far into the night. And as they dance their final waltz, pink and gold clouds flow about them and the pale sun begins to rise.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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